

THE SCREEN TIME MANAGEMENT SYSTEM

A Complete Printable Toolkit to Help Kids

Build Healthy Digital Habits (Ages 3-12)

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Based on AAP (American Academy of Pediatrics) Guidelines

FOR PARENTS: HOW TO USE THIS SYSTEM

This system works because it gives kids OWNERSHIP over their screen time instead of making you the 'screen police.' When kids understand the rules, help track their own time, and earn screen privileges - battles decrease dramatically.

THE 4 COMPONENTS:

- 1. FAMILY RULES (pages 3-5): Establish clear, visual boundaries
- 2. EARN IT SYSTEM (pages 6-12): Tasks completed before screens
- 3. TRACKING (pages 13-20): Kids self-monitor with parent verification
- 4. ALTERNATIVES (pages 21-30): 100 activities to replace screen time

AAP RECOMMENDED LIMITS:

Ages 2-5: Max 1 hour/day of high-quality programming (with adult)

Ages 6-12: Consistent limits, prioritize sleep, activity, homework first

All ages: No screens 1 hour before bed, no screens during meals

TIP: Laminate pages 3-6 and hang them where kids can see daily!

OUR FAMILY SCREEN TIME RULES

(Post this where everyone can see it!)

WE AGREE TO THESE RULES:

1. ☐ Screens are OFF during meals (breakfast, lunch, dinner)
2. ☐ No screens in the bedroom at night
3. ☐ Homework and chores FIRST, screens AFTER
4. ☐ All screens OFF by _____ PM on school nights
5. ☐ All screens OFF by _____ PM on weekends
6. ☐ We ask permission before downloading new apps/games
7. ☐ We tell a parent if we see something scary or confusing online
8. ☐ We take a break every 30 minutes (stretch, blink, move!)
9. ☐ No screens in the car for trips under 30 minutes
10. ☐ We use kind words online (same as in person)

Family rule we want to add: _____

SIGNED:

Child: _____ Date: ____/____/____

Child: _____ Date: ____/____/____

Parent: _____ Date: ____/____/____

Parent: _____ Date: ____/____/____

SCREEN TIME LIMITS (By Age)

(Print and post on the fridge!)

AGES 2-5:

Daily MAX: 1 hour

Type: Educational only (PBS Kids, Khan Academy Kids)

Rule: ALWAYS with a parent watching/discussing

AGES 6-8:

School days: _____ minutes (recommended: 30-60 min)

Weekends: _____ minutes (recommended: 60-90 min)

Type: Mix of educational and entertainment

AGES 9-12:

School days: _____ minutes (recommended: 60-90 min)

Weekends: _____ minutes (recommended: 90-120 min)

Type: Age-appropriate, parent-approved content

ALL AGES - NO SCREEN ZONES:

☒ Dinner table ☒ Bedrooms at night ☒ During homework

☒ 1 hour before bed ☒ First thing in morning

DEVICE-FREE ZONE

(Cut out and place in screen-free areas)

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>>> DEVICE-FREE ZONE <<<

No phones. No tablets. No TV.
Just US being together.

This is a space for:

* Talking * Eating * Reading
* Playing * Sleeping * Creating

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Place in: ☐ Kitchen/Dining ☐ Bedroom ☐ Homework area ☐ _____

EARN YOUR SCREEN TIME!

Complete these FIRST to unlock screen time. No checks = No screens!
(Print a new copy each day or laminate and use dry-erase marker)

BEFORE SCREENS - DAILY CHECKLIST:

MORNING:

- ☐ Made my bed
- ☐ Ate breakfast (at table, no screen)
- ☐ Brushed teeth
- ☐ Got dressed
- ☐ Backpack/lunch ready (school days)

AFTER SCHOOL:

- ☐ Homework DONE (or no homework today)
- ☐ Read for 20 minutes
- ☐ Played outside / physical activity for 30 min
- ☐ One chore completed (_____)
- ☐ Talked to a family member about my day

ALL CHECKS DONE? -----> SCREEN TIME UNLOCKED!

Time earned today: _____ minutes

Timer set? ☐ YES Start time: _____ Stop time: _____

WEEKLY SCREEN TIME TRACKER - Week 1

Child's name: _____ Week of: ____/____/____

DAY	EARNED?	MINUTES USED	WHAT WATCHED/PLAYED	PARENT OK?
Monday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Tuesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Wednesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Thursday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Friday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Saturday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Sunday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐

WEEKLY TOTAL: ____ minutes (Target max: ____ minutes)

Under limit? ☐ YES! Great job! ☐ Over - let's adjust next week

Best day (least screen time): _____

Reward earned this week? ☐ YES -> Reward: _____

WEEKLY SCREEN TIME TRACKER - Week 2

Child's name: _____ Week of: ____/____/____

DAY	EARNED?	MINUTES USED	WHAT WATCHED/PLAYED	PARENT OK?
Monday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Tuesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Wednesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Thursday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Friday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Saturday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Sunday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐

WEEKLY TOTAL: ____ minutes (Target max: ____ minutes)

Under limit? ☐ YES! Great job! ☐ Over - let's adjust next week

Best day (least screen time): _____

Reward earned this week? ☐ YES -> Reward: _____

WEEKLY SCREEN TIME TRACKER - Week 3

Child's name: _____ Week of: ____/____/____

DAY	EARNED?	MINUTES USED	WHAT WATCHED/PLAYED	PARENT OK?
Monday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Tuesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Wednesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Thursday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Friday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Saturday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Sunday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐

WEEKLY TOTAL: ____ minutes (Target max: ____ minutes)

Under limit? ☐ YES! Great job! ☐ Over - let's adjust next week

Best day (least screen time): _____

Reward earned this week? ☐ YES -> Reward: _____

WEEKLY SCREEN TIME TRACKER - Week 4

Child's name: _____ Week of: ____/____/____

DAY	EARNED?	MINUTES USED	WHAT WATCHED/PLAYED	PARENT OK?
Monday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Tuesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Wednesday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Thursday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Friday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Saturday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐
Sunday	☐ Y ☐ N	____ min	_____	☐

WEEKLY TOTAL: ____ minutes (Target max: ____ minutes)

Under limit? ☐ YES! Great job! ☐ Over - let's adjust next week

Best day (least screen time): _____

Reward earned this week? ☐ YES -> Reward: _____

SCREEN TIME TOKEN SYSTEM

Cut out tokens below. Kids earn tokens for good behavior and can 'spend' them on screen time. Makes it tangible and teaches budgeting!

HOW IT WORKS:

1. Child earns tokens for: chores, reading, kindness, outdoor play
2. Each token = 15 minutes of screen time
3. Child decides WHEN to spend tokens (teaches self-regulation!)
4. Unspent tokens at end of week = bonus reward!

EARN TOKENS FOR:

Read 20 min = 1 token | Extra chore = 1 token
Outside 30 min = 1 token | Kindness spotted = 1 token
Homework without fuss = 1 token

TOKENS (cut out - each = 15 min screen time):

[15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN]
[15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN]
[15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN]
[15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN] [15 MIN]

MONTHLY SCREEN TIME REPORT CARD

Month: _____ Child: _____

WEEK 1: Total screen time: ____ hrs ____ min Under limit? ☐ Y ☐ N

WEEK 2: Total screen time: ____ hrs ____ min Under limit? ☐ Y ☐ N

WEEK 3: Total screen time: ____ hrs ____ min Under limit? ☐ Y ☐ N

WEEK 4: Total screen time: ____ hrs ____ min Under limit? ☐ Y ☐ N

MONTHLY TOTAL: ____ hours DAILY AVERAGE: ____ min/day

IMPROVEMENTS THIS MONTH:

☐ Less arguing about screen time

☐ More outdoor/creative play

☐ Better sleep

☐ More family time

☐ Child self-regulating (turning off without being asked)

GRADE: ☐ A (Amazing!) ☐ B (Good progress!) ☐ C (Keep trying!) ☐ Needs work

REWARD EARNED: _____

100 THINGS TO DO INSTEAD OF SCREENS

(Post this on the fridge! When kids say 'I'm bored!' point here.)

1. Build a fort with blankets
2. Draw or color
3. Play with LEGO/blocks
4. Read a book
5. Write a story
6. Play outside
7. Ride a bike
8. Jump rope
9. Play catch
10. Climb a tree
11. Have a dance party
12. Do a puzzle
13. Play board games
14. Play card games
15. Make up a play/skit
16. Build with cardboard boxes
17. Play with play-dough/clay
18. Paint or finger paint
19. Write a letter to grandparent
20. Plant seeds/garden
21. Cook or bake together
22. Do a science experiment
23. Play dress-up
24. Make a treasure hunt
25. Play in the sprinkler
26. Have a picnic
27. Bird watching
28. Fly a kite
29. Play hide and seek
30. Make friendship bracelets
31. Play with pets
32. Visit the library
33. Go for a nature walk
34. Collect rocks/leaves
35. Make a collage
36. Play with bubbles
37. Do yoga/stretching
38. Learn a magic trick
39. Write in a journal
40. Organize your room
41. Call a friend
42. Play an instrument

43. Sing songs
44. Tell jokes
45. Play restaurant/store
46. Build a race track
47. Have a tea party
48. Make paper airplanes
49. Do origami
50. Play with water toys

100 THINGS TO DO (continued)

51. Star gaze at night
52. Play flashlight tag
53. Make shadow puppets
54. Build a birdhouse
55. Press flowers
56. Make a time capsule
57. Learn to juggle
58. Play hopscotch
59. Make slime
60. Write a comic book
61. Play Simon Says
62. Do an obstacle course
63. Make a lemonade stand
64. Play with magnets
65. Make a vision board
66. Play charades
67. Make homemade cards
68. Learn to knit/crochet
69. Do a random act of kindness
70. Play 20 questions
71. Make a family tree
72. Play with sidewalk chalk
73. Build a sandcastle
74. Make a bookmark
75. Go on a bike ride
76. Play tag
77. Make a fort outside
78. Stargaze
79. Tell campfire stories
80. Make your own board game
81. Write a song
82. Do a craft project
83. Play basketball/soccer
84. Go swimming
85. Make a photo album
86. Play with trains/cars
87. Build with sticks outside
88. Make mud pies
89. Have a water balloon fight
90. Learn a new skill
91. Play freeze dance
92. Make a scrapbook
93. Create an invention

94. Go on a scavenger hunt
95. Play monkey in the middle
96. Build domino chain
97. Make sock puppets
98. Play frisbee
99. Do cartwheels
100. ENJOY BEING A KID!

FAMILY MEETING: DIGITAL WELLNESS DISCUSSION

Use these questions for a monthly family check-in about screens:

1. What's your favorite thing to do that doesn't involve a screen?
2. How do you feel AFTER a long time on screens? (tired? wired? sad?)
3. Is there anything you've seen online that confused or upset you?
4. What would you do with an extra hour if screens weren't an option?
5. Do you think our family rules about screens are fair? What would you change?
6. What's one new hobby or skill you'd like to try?
7. How can we help each other put screens down?
8. What's the best part of our screen-free time together?
9. Is anyone at school talking about things they see online? How does that feel?
10. What 'screen-free challenge' should our family try this week?

PARENT TIPS: MAKING THIS WORK

THE FIRST WEEK (Expect pushback!):

- Announce new system at a family meeting - get input
- Start on a weekend when everyone is calm
- Expect 2-3 days of complaints - stay consistent
- Celebrate EVERY day they follow the system
- Lead by example - limit YOUR screen time too!

WHEN THEY PUSH BACK (and they will):

Say: 'I understand you're frustrated. The rules still apply.'

Say: 'You can earn more screen time by [specific task].'

Say: 'What from the 100 activities list sounds fun right now?'

Don't say: 'Because I said so!' (explain the WHY)

SIGNS THE SYSTEM IS WORKING:

- ☐ Less arguing about screen time
- ☐ Child asks for activities instead of screens
- ☐ Better sleep (falling asleep faster)
- ☐ More creativity and independent play
- ☐ Child self-regulates (turns off without being told)
- ☐ More family conversation and connection

Remember: Progress > Perfection. Even 30% less screen time = better outcomes.

By Daniel Tesfamariam | Raising humans, not screen zombies.